

Korea Financials & Fintech: SG marketing feedback: Finding value as defensives amid market volatility

We see KR financials as defensives given solid dividend yields

Amid increased market volatility, our investor discussions focused around defensives, where we see KR financials well-placed with earnings becoming more resilient and as Value Up efforts (i.e., higher payouts incl. buybacks and cancellation, high-dividend company qualification, tax-exempt dividends) have pushed up the underlying yields. While the sectoral preference have tilted towards KR insurers more recently, we see value in both KR banks and insurance amid the increased market volatility.

Sinyoung Park
+82(2)3788-1778 |
sinyoung.park@gs.com
Goldman Sachs (Asia) L.L.C., Seoul
Branch

KR Banks taking a pause but we see further upside

With KR banks lifting TSR levels to c.50% in 2025A, investors seem to agree that large commercial banks can reach 1x P/B on 10-11% ROE. While Shinhan/Woori recently renewed Value Up targets, we think the bar is now higher post 2024-25 re-rating and well-anchored expectations. While KR bank shares were sidelined in the recent rally due to lack of near-term catalysts and growing social responsibilities, we still see further upside as they are in the late-stage valuation re-rating phase.

KR insurers gaining traction with improving fundamentals and Value Up potential

We saw rising interest on KR insurers as select non-life insurers began to show a positive trend reversal in underwriting quality, after years of deteriorating loss ratio trends and heightened competition. Coupled with positive regulatory measures in 2H26E (i.e., GA commission cap, stricter claims review), we expect to see more visible operational improvements. With our expectation for earnings expected to become more stable and growing external pressure, investors are looking for faster Value Up enhancements.

Limited interest in fintech until the next round of updates on stablecoin

Both Kakaopay and KakaoBank shares displayed stronger share price reaction to stablecoin-related developments, but we sense that investor perception on the underlying fundamentals are different — Kakaopay began delivering revenue growth acceleration and sequentially driving up its OPM while KakaoBank's deposit growth has softened, potentially due to the ongoing retail money move and its lending growth being hindered by regulations. All-in-all, we believe the market is waiting for tangible stablecoin related developments that can level up the growth trajectories.

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Exhibit 1: Summary valuation table for Korea Financials/Fintech coverage

Ticker	Company	Mkt Cap (KRW bn)	3M ADTV (KRW bn)	Rating	TP	Last Price	Up/Down side	P/B		P/E		ROE		ROA		Div. Yield		TSR Yield	
								2026E	2027E	2026E	2027E	2026E	2027E	2026E	2027E	2026E	2027E	2026E	2027E
Korea Banks																			
105560.KS	KB Financial Group	63,510	195	Buy	203,000	160,000	26.9%	0.96x	0.88x	8.3x	7.4x	11.6%	11.8%	0.79%	0.80%	3.1%	3.5%	6.1%	6.9%
055550.KS	Shinhan Financial Group	46,463	141	Buy	114,000	98,200	16.1%	0.80x	0.73x	8.3x	7.3x	10.0%	10.5%	0.67%	0.71%	3.0%	3.4%	6.5%	7.5%
086790.KS	Hana Financial Group	36,530	109	Buy	144,000	122,100	17.9%	0.69x	0.64x	7.5x	6.6x	10.2%	10.5%	0.62%	0.65%	3.8%	4.3%	6.0%	6.8%
316140.KS	Woori Financial Group	22,778	80	Neutral	35,500	31,550	12.5%	0.63x	0.57x	6.7x	5.7x	9.5%	10.1%	0.53%	0.60%	4.9%	5.6%	6.7%	8.2%
323410.KS	KakaoBank Corp.	10,832	39	Neutral	26,000	22,800	14.0%	1.61x	1.53x	17.1x	15.3x	9.4%	10.3%	0.80%	0.81%	2.9%	3.3%	-	-
139130.KS	IM Financial Group	3,200	14	Neutral	16,500	18,920	-12.8%	0.53x	0.46x	5.5x	4.7x	9.4%	9.9%	0.50%	0.53%	4.2%	4.6%	6.5%	7.5%
024110.KS	Industrial Bank of Korea	12,035	31	Sell	17,000	21,000	-19.0%	0.51x	0.48x	6.0x	5.7x	8.1%	8.2%	0.51%	0.51%	5.7%	6.2%	-	-
138930.KS	BNK Financial Group	5,694	21	Sell	14,000	17,470	-19.9%	0.47x	0.41x	6.4x	5.6x	7.8%	8.1%	0.50%	0.53%	3.5%	4.2%	6.4%	7.3%
Korea Insurance																			
000810.KS	Samsung F&M	22,662	81	Buy	660,000	569,000	16.0%	0.69x	0.67x	10.6x	10.2x	8.2%	7.0%	2.20%	2.21%	4.0%	4.7%	-	-
005830.KS	DB Insurance	9,780	44	Buy	190,000	154,500	23.0%	0.91x	0.83x	6.9x	5.8x	13.5%	15.0%	2.34%	2.61%	5.6%	6.5%	-	-
001450.KS	Hyundai M&F	3,082	22	Buy	47,000	38,650	21.6%	0.52x	0.45x	3.7x	3.4x	15.3%	14.3%	1.66%	1.78%	0.0%	7.8%	-	-
032830.KS	Samsung Life	65,455	98	Neutral	245,000	364,500	-32.8%	0.49x	0.48x	22.5x	16.0x	3.0%	3.0%	0.79%	1.04%	2.0%	2.9%	-	-
138040.KS	Meritz FG	20,978	36	Sell	100,000	109,200	-8.4%	1.45x	1.12x	7.2x	6.2x	25.4%	24.2%	1.85%	1.90%	1.2%	1.2%	6.9%	7.1%
088350.KS	Hanwha Life	4,208	61	Sell	2,900	5,600	-48.2%	0.39x	0.37x	9.1x	8.4x	4.6%	4.6%	0.36%	0.37%	-	-	-	-
Korea Fintech																			
323410.KS	KakaoBank Corp.	10,832	39	Neutral	26,000	22,800	14.0%	1.61x	1.53x	17.1x	15.3x	9.4%	10.3%	0.80%	0.81%	2.9%	3.3%	-	-
377300.KS	Kakaopay Corp	6,745	60	Neutral	58,000	50,000	16.0%	3.28x	2.97x	43.6x	30.7x	7.8%	10.2%	2.64%	3.26%	-	-	-	-

Based on 22 May 2026 closing price; all target prices are on a 12-month basis; TSR yield is applicable to companies implementing share buybacks/cancellation

Source: Quantwise, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

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Contributing Authors: Sinyoung Park Goldman Sachs (Asia) L.L.C., Seoul Branch.

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